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Hona Maria

The story of this lonely Indian woman-hermit, who lived entirely alone for eighteen years, on one of the islands of the Santa Barbara Channel, is now but a tradition with the present generation.

Written by Josephine Clifford in 1872.

SOUTHWARD from the quaint town of Santa Barbara, beyond the Santa Barbara Bay—with its high-arching isles, summery winds and the softened splendor of semi-tropical skies—five leagues out in the ocean, the island of San Nicolas lifts its brown, rugged outline from the surging waters. Hidden from the mainland by Santa Cruz, an island of greater magnitude, the sun seems to rise from the purpled rim of the waters, and to set where the golden seas meet the horizon of the golden skies. The waves wash far up the sloping, sandy shore, and, receding, leave bright shells, tangled kelp, and smooth, wave-polished stones. The seals sun themselves on the crystalized rocks, and gaze at the intruder with almost human eyes. The sea-wasps shake their delicate wings in the bright atmosphere; and strange birds call from the high branches of unfamiliar trees. Deep pools lie hidden in lonely gorges, and fold their secrets forever in their dark bosoms. The wild dogs bark from the shelving rocks, and, with uncanny faces dart into the close ravine.

Years and years ago ere the energies of the white settlers had made their impress upon the wilderness along the Pacific shore, a tribe of Indians existed on this now desolate isle. Of what they thought, suffered, hoped or accomplished, we have only scanty tradition. Now and then a pirate's craft anchored along the quiet shore, and, departing, told no tale. Sometimes

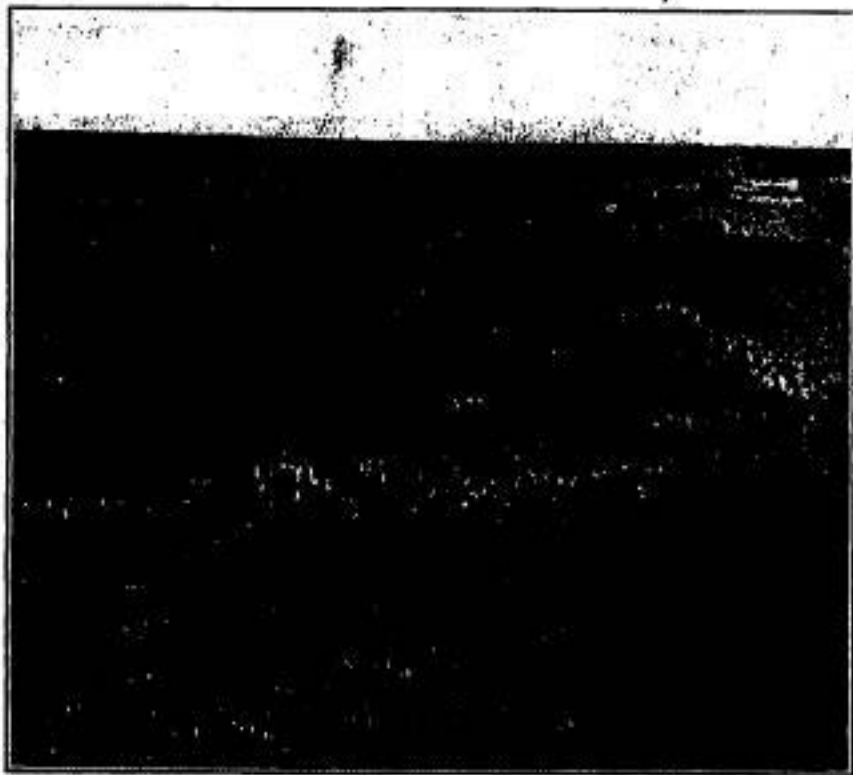
the friendly voice of the mission fathers stole across the calm bay; and the shadow of the Cross, planted in the wilderness, threw its benign influence over the undeveloped children of the sun. But the Fathers sleep, and left no record.

Thirty-six years ago the famine found this isolated band, and clutched them with its gaunt, relentless hand. The parched earth refused her sustenance; the trees stood bare and leafless in the hot wind; the streams ran dry, and the rocks glittered white and salt under the fervid sun. The wild game famished and died; and the fierce preyed upon each other. With pitying horror, these human beings stared into each other's faces, and, with stoical fortitude, crawled away to die alone. Whether the Mission Fathers learned of their distress, or whether urged by other motives, it is not known; but they fitted out a boat, which sailed to San Nicholas and brought away the survivors—eighteen in all. As the rescued islanders were brought down to the shore where the boat was anchored, one of the women—who afterwards gave her name as Hona Maria—darted away, over the sandy shore, over rough rocks, through tangled ravines, with savage eagerness, to bring her only child which, by some oversight, had been left behind. They waited for her re-appearance—they waited long. The skies darkened; the winds arose and tossed the unsteady

boat from her frail anchorage, and the reluctant captain was compelled to put out to sea; and Hona Maria was left alone on that desolate, sea-walled isle.

The thick fog shut down over the ocean, and the heavy swell of the waves tossed the boat rapidly toward the mainland. The rescued Indians were kindly cared for by the humane people of Santa Barbara; but, either from past suffering or the unaccustomed influences of civilization, they died or dispersed to wilder surroundings. The boat was wrecked, preventing another expedition to the islands, and for years was not replaced. Hona Maria was sup-

Monterey, and, in one of his cruises, anchored at the tragic island of San Nicholas. On wandering over the island, he found traces of human life; ashes yet warm—a footprint in the soil. But again the storm beat down upon the shore and compelled the small crew to put to sea. With clear skies and becalmed seas they returned. Again, the smoldering fire—the trace in the sand; and, after a short search, to their amazement Hona Maria herself—the Hermit Monarch of this lonely isle! Without the least sign of surprise she gazed, for the first time in eighteen years, upon human faces. In unintelligible language, but with expressive, savage



"The seals sun themselves and gaze at the intruder with almost human eyes"

posed to have died, and no heart turned to the lonely island.

Eighteen solitary years had passed. White faces peered over the rocky battlement of mountains and browned under the California sun. Avenues of communication and commerce were opened, and the mysteries of the Golden State were penetrated. Captain Nidever, a resident of Santa Barbara, fitted a schooner at

gestures, she made them understand that the dogs killed her child. This was the burden of her limited expressions—this longing for human sympathy amid her tragic desolation—bursting the bondage of unintelligible language, and making the grand sorrow of her savage heart known and felt.

A rude hut, constructed of interlaced branches, sticks and leaves, constituted her

shelter. A fantastic robe of gayly feathered bird skins, neatly dressed and adroitly stitched with fine tendons, by the aid of needles manufactured from fish bones, covered her dusky limbs, and another of brighter hues were ready for time of need, or possibly reserved for her solitary festivals. Many rude treasures, collected during her hermitage, were transferred to the boat, and afterward landed at Santa Barbara. With astonishment she beheld the mainland. Her rapid glance took in the coast and the placid valley, girdled by the rugged mountains, sloping to the bay. From the narrow limits of her island-home, the sea only was vast, stretching away beyond the range of vision.

received, pleased with gifts and kindness, like a child in a new creation. She spoke a dialect entirely different from the native Spanish or Indians of the Santa Barbara region. A short time previous to her death, which occurred six months after her departure from her native island, an Indian woman was found who could interpret her strange tongue. She had not much to tell. A life more colorless, devoid of imagery or experience, it is impossible to conceive. The effect of long seclusion, upon her mind so crude and undeveloped, cannot be conjectured. In her solitary abode she knew the ways of the birds of the air and the fishes of the sea, and fashioned nets to capture them,



"—she knew the ways of the birds of the air and the fishes of the sea—"

The boundless view of land presented a new and strange geographical development to her uneducated mind. A "solitary horseman" galloping along the smooth beach caused her ecstasies of delight, which she expressed in long, wild peals of laughter and fantastic dances. A team with oxen completed her amusement. She observed the unfamiliar actions of people and animals with child-like pleasure, yet never forgot her lost child, nor the horrible manner of its death. She was proud of the attention she

which, with seals and roots, furnished her sustenance.

Large sums of money were refused by Captain Nidever for the possession of the woman, as an attractive addition to a museum; but she was kindly guarded at his private residence, and in 1853 she passed to the spirit-land. The Bishop took possession of her ingeniously manufactured robes and carried them to Rome.

Hona Maria sleeps on the quiet hillside; and her strange fate, hitherto, has been a dim tradition.

